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GRAMDAN MOVEMENT

Onward March

A TURNING POINT

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मराठवाडा

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ग्रंथ नोंदणी प्रमाण

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Judged by any standard of human achievement so far, the results of the Gramdan movement are unprecedented and it can safely be said that Shri Vinobaji is adding a new chapter to the history of Human progress—and this has been achieved purely through persuasion, that is, by education with emphasis on conversion.

But, however great man's achievement may be, it is always sure to fall short of his aspirations and objectives. This is the price that man has to pay for being a conscious being. Man's quest in this respect is eternal. So he can never afford to rest on his oars.

The Gramdan movement has the objective of establishing a Sarvodaya order based on direct and participatory democracy which alone can ensure freedom, equality and justice to all the members of the community. If this order is not to remain ever an ideal but is to become the daily life of the community, then all resources from the spiritual to the material must be at the disposal of the community for the use of every member for his or her fulfilment. Where members of the community, as free men, bear the responsibility and are in control of production of all kinds of wealth and enjoy it according to their need, there will not be two classes—one by its physical labour producing wealth and the other intellectually enjoying it. There will be a true brotherhood of man in which all things are common. There will be no manager and managed; people in all fields of life will manage their own affairs. The consciousness of the present civilized man is determined by his being and this has fractured his person into owner and owned,

master and servant. It is next to impossible for him to imagine a social order where there is no master and manager. The present master-manager-ridden society cannot imagine that people, with spontaneity and ability natural to them, can take control and administer their own life.

Here one must blaze a new trail. There is no charter to guide except faith in man. It is unnecessary to say that there will also be no blue-print. This future, though brought up and nourished in the womb of the present, will be absolutely different from it. Therefore, what we must agree on are the general principles of the society we want to create. In this society man will have not only greater mastery over his environment, including science and technology, but over his own self also.

One of these general principles is the universalization of the means of producing wealth so that it may be available for the good of all. It is said that this can be brought about by socialization or communisation ; but it must be remembered that contemporary history of more than half a century has shown that mere abolition of the private ownership of the means of production, essential though it is, does not necessarily mean the end of exploitation.

Why does it so happen ? Simply because the socialization of the means of production is *per se* merely an economic fact. Its claim to be the beginning of a new social order depends on what man does with the socialized means of production. So far socialization has failed to do this because the means adopted were inadequate, if not opposite, to the ends. Socialization brought about naturally by the development of means and methods of production, a historical process (foreseen by Marx that this would happen in England) or brought about forcibly by violence (by Lenin in Russia) does not take into account the agent, namely, man. Neither by mere natural evolution nor by coercion is man changed essentially. That can be done only through self-enlightenment. Fear or mere economic gratification will not transform man ; and a new man is the *sine qua non* of the new society. The real meaning of revolution is not a change in management, but a change in man. This new man will make all the difference. He will use these socialized means of production for the development and

gratification of the free individual ; if this does not happen, socialization will simply amount to a new form for subjugating individuals to a hypostasized universality, namely, the society. The abolition of private property inaugurates an essentially new social system only if free individuals and not the society—an abstraction opposed to the individual—become master of the socialised means of production.

Here the Gramdan movement has decidedly an edge over the Marxian way in two respects. First, it believes in bringing about socialization of the means of production through persuasion and conversion of man ; and secondly, it believes in villagization rather than nationalization or socialization.

But the Gramdan movement has to fight against time and also against mounting violence, not only in this country but all over the world. People have suffered terribly for long ; if people have not already lost faith in the goodness of man, they are losing it fast. In this context it was really providential for Vinobaji to ask the worker to carry on the work of Gramdan with the velocity of a storm (*Toofan Gramdan*). The quick results achieved during the last three years since the movement entered its new phase have more than vindicated the validity of the inner promptings of Vinobaji. But it cannot be denied that these quick and encouraging results have been achieved at some cost to the fundamentals of the movement. It can be justifiably said that for this the movement has to retrace two big steps backwards. The original Gramdan required the land-owner to surrender his ownership as well as his entire land to the village community. It was the village community which distributed the surrendered land according to certain principles and the land-owner was entitled only to get his share accordingly. This was really a revolutionary measure which communised the entire land of the village, ownership as well as the mode and measure of using and sharing. It was entirely in the hands of the village community. But experience proved that this kind of Gramdan was not an easily negotiable commodity with the land-owner, and the movement made very little progress. There was a kind of stalemate. Vinobaji's *Sulabha Gramdan* was in response to this state of things and it has been proved correct

to a certain extent. The *Sulabha Gramdan* no doubt asks the owners of land to surrender their ownership but leaves nineteen-twentieths of their land for use to them and to their successors in perpetuity. In Bhoodan Vinobaji had come to asking the land-owners one-sixth of their total land ; in *Sulabha Gramdan*, he is satisfied only with one-twentieth. The effect of this is that actually, at least for some time to come, there will be comparatively very little land at the disposal of the village community for distribution amongst the landless. The surrender of ownership of land to the village community by the owners is no doubt a great step forward, but the way in which the economic life of the community during the last two centuries, especially due to science and technology, has developed, it is more the right of use and not the ownership that really matters. Thus it will have to be admitted that though the movement has made great strides because of *Sulabha Gramdan* it has also to a certain extent taken the edge off the revolutionary side of this movement. The natural corollary of this process is that the Gramdan movement, though revolutionary in spirit, has tended in practice to be only a reformatory one. Though ownership is surrendered, the use to a very large extent is retained ; the actual relation between the landless farm worker and the land-owner undergoes no significant change. The land-owner continues to enjoy the dominant position in the economy of the village even after one-twentieth of his land is distributed among the landless section, for his hereditary occupancy right over his remaining portion is guaranteed under the terms of the *Sulabha Gramdan*. Thus the movement as it is today cannot bring a qualitative transformation in the structure of village economy. Practically, the *status quo* remains intact.

The leaders (and there are still 'leaders' in this movement in spite of Vinobaji's insistence on everybody becoming a lamp unto himself) and the rank and file must be aware of the measure and quality of their achievements in relation to the goals set for the movement ; that will help them to take the next right step in their forward march. They have first to take note of the fact that in spite of phenomenal expansion, the movement has no real depth and it is still the worker's movement and not the people's movement. For the criterion

generally accepted for a people's movement is that it must produce a levelling impact on the society, that is, the village community must experience a real change both at the structural and also at an attitudinal level. The people and their attitude to ideas and institutions must undergo a fundamental change. The second criterion is that a truly social and economic popular movement is bound to influence the policies of the government of the day, and force it to reorient its policies in the context of the objectives visualized by the movement. It must produce institutions at the village level replacing the functions of the older ones which, however functional with reference to the old village social structure preceding the change, are essentially exploitative in character. In particular the spirit of this movement must be responsive to the great fact that the old closed Indian society is fast advancing towards a free modern society and it has constructively to welcome it. But the emergence of these new institutions should be spontaneous. The people must feel its glory and the necessity to create it. Emergence of a new leadership, preferably from the weaker and exploited section of the community, is indispensable for this to happen.

The most zealous advocates of the movement will, I am sure, admit that the movement does not, at least at present, satisfy these criteria. To those who are in the movement and those who are close observers of it, the cause is quite obvious. Whatever is achieved so far is truly the result of one man's, Vinobaji's, *Sankalpa-Shakti*. Hundreds of workers, many of them belonging to various Khadi organizations, have been inspired by him and they have thrown themselves into the movement. Yet the fact cannot be denied that the movement has hardly touched the fringe of the people. So much so that even many a dedicated worker feels disappointed, nay, even frustrated for want of people's enthusiasm and their real participation in it. Secondly, this *Sankalpa* is detonated by the time-limit bomb so that it may become more explosive (that is the argument one generally hears in this respect). But in this connection one must not forget that human consciousness cannot be planned. As a result not only has this not succeeded in bringing the people in the movement but it has affected

the quality of the movement to a great extent. This is the reason why there is so large a time gap between *Prapti* and *Pushti*. *Nirman* has hardly begun except in a few pockets in various States and that is more or less social development work aided by outside, or in some cases by foreign, help.

The few hundreds of Gram Sabhas, relatively a poor number, which have come into being are mainly due to the efforts of the workers. One does not see a spontaneous upsurge on the part of the people to start building their life on a new foundation. The workers who are helping the working of the Gram Sabhas generally find apathy on the part of the village people as a whole. The people are not enthusiastic. The cause of this want of enthusiasm, if not absolute apathy, according to many workers is that the poor—and they are the majority—are suspicious and the comparatively rich, though their number is not large, are afraid.

Now when we are starting on the second lap of our journey, namely, *Pushti* and *Nirman* on a large scale, the first question that we have to ask ourselves and also solve is how to make this movement really popular, that is, how to make it a people's movement? The answer is simple. The movement can become popular only when people participate in it, especially in decision-making; that alone will make them take the responsibility of implementing those decisions. The movement will then produce its own leaders. For this to happen, in my opinion it is absolutely necessary that *Sankalpa*-taking and especially detonating it by the time-limit bomb must be given up. The movement, as it is, has sufficiently widened and now it needs no such artificial device to help it grow. Henceforward the workers' role should be that of an external catalytic agent. The people of the villages themselves and their natural leaders will decide the programme and methods of carrying on the work of *Pushti* and even of *Nirman*. Not quantity but quality must guide us in our future advance.

If the movement has to make great strides and become self-propelling and if it has to achieve its objectives in a measurable time, we will have to find the correct answer to the question why the poor in the village are suspicious of the utility and effectiveness of the Gram Sabhas and why the rich are afraid of them? In this adventure the experience of the

community development programmes so far undertaken in the country will be of much use to us. Everybody knows that in all the programmes the people have not responded and have not come forward for bettering their life. Are the poor to be solely held responsible for this, or their indifference if not apathy, or are there other factors also?

To find this we will not have to dive very deep in the current of the life of the village in the present-day India. The stratification of the village community on the basis of caste and class at present is due to unequal social status and economic holdings. This is so obvious that it needs no buttressing by facts and figures. Everybody knows that a great majority of the people in the villages are landless or workless and are, therefore, very poor. It is the few, because of their caste superiority and economic power, that dominate the life of an overwhelming majority in all fields in the village life, and the Harijans everywhere are the worst sufferers in this respect. They live admittedly in miserable conditions. It is no wonder that this is the prevalent order. For the law that regulates the relations of the inhabitants of the jungle regulates also the relations of the inhabitants of the villages and towns of the human community. If there are some oases in the desert or islands in the sea, they simply prove the law of exception. This has led to alienation of man ; when men deal with other men, they are neither conscious of their own humanity nor are they conscious of that of other men. This alienation is the root cause of all kinds of exploitation of man by man and violence today. Whoever may be the doctor dealing with the malady of the present day village life, if he is to remain true to his mission he has to accept this fact of exploitation in the village life. The diagnosis of all these doctors will be the same ; their prescriptions may differ, nay, have to differ, because, this is not a physical but a social disease. The worker in this movement also cannot deny this reality or refuse to see it. If he thinks that his faith and his way of dealing with social and economic problems demand that he will not see it or recognise it, he will do so at his peril. He is bound to harm the cause he is out to serve. One cannot refuse to see the reality as it is, nor can one afford to interpret it according to one's own philosophy. For reality does not brook any kind of inter-

pretation ; that will only lead the interpreter astray. As the Adya Shankaracharya says, "Application of attributes to the Atma does not bring about any change in the Atma. He even then remains attributeless".

Just as the fish is conscious of the water in which he breathes and lives, so also every member of the exploited and weaker section of the community of the village is conscious of this exploitation. This is today the breath and life of human society all over the world. That is why the poor has suspicion in his heart. It naturally is very difficult for him to believe that there can be any man or any institution which wants to put an end to this long-time game of exploitation of which he has so long been a victim. The same law works with the rich who are very conscious of their interests and are ready to fight any man or any institution which they suspect is out to challenge their hereditary power or stop the exploitation. All this is merely a question of survival, that is why there is always a clash of interests in human society. Marx was not very wrong when he said, "The history of the development of human society is the history of class struggle". There is some room for difference in the interpretation of history ; but one will have to admit that there is much truth also in what Marx said. Man may not be a wholly material being as Marx seems to describe, but even the greatest advocates of the spirituality of man cannot deny that though man is an animal who lives on land, he is still an ambivalent creature ; while living on land he lives on many planes and today an overwhelming number of men live a major portion of their life on the material plane, with the result that their consciousness is much determined by their being on that plane. They, therefore, are still essentially brutes and naturally the law of their existence also is brute force. Gramdan *per se* has not brought about any real change in this situation. Therefore, the worker in the Gramdan movement must have no doubt in his mind about his place in the community. He is for all. He is as much for the strong and the exploiter as he is for the weak and the exploited. But the community must see him always standing by the side of the weak. He must be quite clear in his thinking with regard to the ideals and sections for whom he stands. He is for the exploiter, because he believes that the latter is

capable of being redeemed, but he cannot be by his side for helping him to maintain the *status quo*. So also the worker must be always aware that he gives no ground to the weak for an impression that he is unable to go with them in their fight against the strong. No doubt he must be firmly wedded to the methods of persuasion and conversion. He will be always ready for the right kind of compromise, but must be equally wedded to the cause of the exploited. Only this way he can succeed in driving out the suspicion from the hearts of the poor and make them self-confident, because of their confidence in him. For this, complete identification with the people on the part of the worker is essential. The gap today in the social, economic and cultural life of the people of different classes is very wide. It will be wrong for the worker to assume that as soon as individual land-owners begin to sit in the Gram Sabha the alchemy of the Gram Sabha will transform them and their dealings with the poor and the weak will change. He must not forget that however altruistically motivated individuals might be, they have their own aspirations and interests to serve and in the workings of the Gram Sabha, these inspirations and interests are bound to be reflected. These individuals will fight to safeguard them. Therefore, in the Gram Sabha the worker must always be the champion of the cause of the poor and the exploited. Though he himself will not fight, he must help them to fight all kinds of exploitation in the life of the village community. He must help the weak to resist the domination and exploitation of the strong and the rich. For a long time this will be necessary. Yet though the worker will be the watch-dog of the interests of the weaker sections in the village, he will not allow the village people to make the Gram Sabha a cockpit of warring interests in the village; he will also ~~allow~~ ^{not} allow the powerful vested interests in the village or outside to make the Gram Sabha their instrument to dominate or exploit the poor. The worker by his moral force of character and service of the whole community will so guide the deliberations of the Gram Sabha that it will be an instrument in the hands of the villagers to iron out their differences through informative discussions and smoothen their relations by a mutual understanding arrived at by appeal, persuasion leading to conversion and joint efforts for common

veal. This can be called confrontation at the human, that is, moral level, because at this level the human element in the dominant group will have to be articulated through face-to-face confrontation.

Because the present social order has prevailed for ages, some of the social and economic interests have got themselves entrenched and they have become part and parcel of the life of some of the classes. Interests make men's hearts hard as granite and impervious to the sufferings of others. To melt such hearts application of some more energy would sometimes be necessary. When someone asked Gandhiji why he resorted to Satyagraha when he believed in the power and efficacy of the word, he gave some such answer. So in the course of future development occasions may arise when the confrontation on the human plane may have to be supplemented with confrontation in the field, that is, with direct action of various kinds. Every struggle need not begin with direct action but the latter must have a place when all other approaches have failed in inducing the powerful interests to do justice. They may sometimes show reluctance to put into practice what they acknowledge as just in the course of human confrontation, that is, in the Gram Sabhas. This confrontation in the field may assume the form of direct opposition, for example, in the case of eviction or suppression; it may assume the form of non-co-operation, in other words, satyagraha, for example, in cases of wage dispute or the refusal of the weaker sections to co-operate with the dominant group in agricultural operations; or it may actually take the form of obstructing operations in the field, depending upon the specific situation in the area. The worker will have to organize the landless or other exploited segments of the village community since he is working for the weaker sections. The worker in the course of his life or service will have to face many such realities; he should not be scared of class conflict. The only qualification that will govern this approach is that it will be strictly non-violent. In the peasant struggle in Champaran against the Indigo planters Gandhiji had started organizing the peasants and if the government had not yielded in what I have called the moral or human confrontation, the world would have got a model Gandhian type of peasants' organization just as it has

got a labour organization in Ahmedabad. So we should have no qualms in organizing a class; it would only mean being *more* loyal to the king himself. *Chan*.

But after Gramdan, the context in the life of the village community is completely changed. The ownership of land, one of the main means of producing wealth is vested in the village community. And secondly, there is the Gram Sabha, an organization of the whole village whose curbs and controls, though to a limited extent, the people have accepted in their dealings with one another. As I have stated here before, in a forum or an organization on the village level the weaker sections can carry on a continuous moral confrontation with stronger ones. If the weaker sections show sufficient courage this can be a permanent non-violent revolution ennobling both the sections in the process. In this changed context, I think that in the interest of the weaker sections themselves it would not be wise to organize them in different class organizations and thus make the confrontation a class confrontation. The quality of our confrontation is moral. For this kind of moral confrontation what is needed is to build the moral strength of the parties. Class organizations are not the proper instruments for this task. The moral strength of the people can more effectively be built through what Gandhiji called his constructive programme—a programme whose main aim and function is to build the life of the community by voluntary constructive efforts which lead to mutual co-operation of a high intensity. In his draft constitution for the 'Loka Sevak Sangh' Gandhiji had suggested that the All India Constructive Organization which he had founded and built during the non-violent struggle against the foreign government should be affiliated to the Loka Sevak Sangh. The Gramdan movement can take a leaf from this draft of Gandhiji and form such constructive organisations not at the all-India nor even at the State level, but at the level of the village, block and district. This will enable the people to build their moral strength without dividing themselves into classes. In this case, if the poor classes have eventually to fight the stronger ones with Satyagraha in the field they will have the moral support and help of some of the people belonging to this class. Thus the course of the future development of society may not be that

of class struggle as Marx says but of class collaboration to establish justice because of the new means adopted.

II

In the work of *Nirman* also we have to follow certain guiding principles. The first and foremost amongst them is the definition of 'Swadeshi' by Gandhiji. He called it 'the law of life'. He defined Swadeshi as a way of life in which man confined his services and needs to his neighbourhood. This neighbourhood would expand like the ever-widening concentric ocean circles. This expansion would not be vertical but horizontal. Gandhiji wanted to build an alternative society to the present based on truth and non-violence. Distance lends enchantment to the view. Therefore, man looks to the distant lands in his day-to-day life at the cost of the immediate, which is an embodiment of the hard reality of life. Man wants to escape from this hard reality. Therefore in his search for happiness he lives a superficial life. The application of this law which is true only in the inanimate nature to human society makes man an escapist. This escapism brings about alienation of man, leading to all kinds of exploitation and violence. The immediate neighbour whom he can really serve he neglects, and in his vain search for happiness he deceives himself that he is serving the distant man. This way of dealing with human life makes man look upon every man with whom he deals not as a man but as an object to be used for his pleasures in life. Man must be helped to avoid this temptation. Even in this age of advanced science and technology, man has to follow the law of Swadeshi in his life as far as possible.

This law of swadeshi will automatically lead to the law of simplicity. In our new search for freedom, equality and justice we have to turn our backs on the slogan of "raising the standard of living". The West has adopted this law for its life, which they are imposing upon the rest of the world in the name of civilization and culture. Their advanced technology and industrialization and their comparatively miserly

patronage tempts the rest of mankind to imitate them. Gandhiji had turned his back firmly against this civilization; he stood for the principle of 'simple living and high thinking'. As the late Shri Kishorilal Mashruwalla put it, he believed in raising "the standard of life and not of living".

Even in the West which has now plenty to eat, people are realizing the truth of what Christ had said: 'Man does not live by bread alone'. Those who have plenty to feed are fed up with their material and monotonous life and are in search of a new qualitative life. Shall we go by the same way that the West has gone in search of material plenty and then only begin to think of a new way of life? Unfortunately, we have made no other use of our freedom than blindly to imitate the West in all fields of life from the spiritual to the material.

We talk much of our ancient spiritual and cultural heritage and are proud of our glorious civilization but so far we have not given any indication of it in building a new India. In these days of science and technology, the real test is in the type of industrialism we choose. So far there is no proof to show that we are choosing essentially a different way from capitalism or communism. Nowadays even the word 'mixed economy' has gone out of use. It is officially declared that our goal is democratic socialism and more and more state control over the life of the people is sought for and is becoming popular. There is nothing to show in our way of development that we are going by a new way. Our ends will naturally determine our means.

Today, in the whole West from America to Russia, whether the country is democratic or dictatorial, regardless of the difference in the political and social systems as far as the kind of technology and the type of industrialism are concerned, there is practically no difference. They are all striving to create what is called a Consumers' Society where there is plenty to eat and plenty to drink. This society is leading to ennui and monotony of life, so much so that men are losing their nerve and everywhere we see signs of revolt against the established order of things.

The real point is what kind of industrialism we adopt and

that will depend upon the way of life we choose. Writings about the ancient Indian village communities clearly show that it was the quality of simplicity of their life that enabled them to preserve themselves against various vicissitudes of life that history had imposed upon them. It would be wrong to equate simplicity with poverty. Simplicity is the quality of the soul, a value in life. It does not mean a life of want; it simply means a balanced life—a way of life in which the material is not the end but the means to realize the moral and the spiritual. The end of life cannot always be to satisfy its ever-increasing material wants. There must be a limit to it; life itself should become a means for realizing higher ends.

In this respect, the division of life into four *ashramas* on Dharma in the old Indian way of life is worthy not only of consideration but of revival. According to this way of life, having enjoyed the pleasures and boons of life as a householder, man voluntarily reduced his material wants in the next two ashramas, namely, *Vanaprastha* and *Sanyas* and gave himself up to realization of higher values of life. This voluntary renunciation not only checked the increase of wants in one's life but also determined the measure of increasing them. Here one may naturally be asked whether in this age of advanced technology and industrialism it is possible for a man to voluntarily reduce his wants and take to a simple way of life? The simple answer to this question is that if it is desirable then the very technology that seems an obstacle in the way will become man's handmaid. Ultimately man is not for technology; it is technology that must serve the social values and ends of man's life. We are often told that this is an age of technological miracles. This is all the greater reason why it should help man to build a new society where he may keep in touch with the real life of other people by following the law of Swadeshi of Gandhiji. The new technology may enable the immediate producers themselves to create, by their own labour and leisure, their own progress and determine its rate and direction. In that case self-determination would proceed from the base and work for the necessities could transcend itself towards work for gratification.

Why should the type of industrialization so far evolved by the advanced countries of the West be supposed as the only possible type and imposed upon the rest of the world? Cannot these countries, according to their genius and past culture, their particular conditions of development, evolve a new type of technology and an indigenous method of development and progress?

The very fact that we are not very much advanced like some of the countries in the West or in the East may be a factor in our favour. We should evolve a kind of technology which would, instead of suppressing our way of life and labour, would improve and extend them. It would do away with all kinds of exploitation and enable people to live a decent life of freedom and equality which will really develop the quality of their life. This would no doubt demand a planned policy which instead of superimposing advanced technology on the traditional modes of life and labour, would extend and improve them on their own grounds, eliminating all kinds of suppressive and exploitative forces. No doubt a social revolution would be necessary, but that may save these countries from industrialization after the pattern of advanced societies of the West or East.

Fortunately for us the conditions in this country, in spite of blind imitation of the West by our politicians and planners, are still such that it is not too late for us to write on a clean slate if not absolutely on an Indian slate. Though as a result of past twenty-two years' Western type of planning some gigantic projects have come up in the country and some metropolitan cities are growing into monstrosities, India still remains a rural society. The Gramdan movement has also demonstrated that our ancient culture is still a living force influencing the hearts and heads of the common people. If we march with faith and courage, we can still adopt a new kind of technology and a way of industrialization essentially different from the advanced countries of the world, and establish an order of society which is truly decentralized and participatory, where men know each other and work for each other on the basis of freedom, equality and justice.

The Gram Sabha is the cornerstone of this new societal structure. It must be made strong and effective. This can only happen when the Gram Sabha takes over effectively the property and leadership of the village. This can only happen through people's participation and fighting all kinds of injustices in the village life.

I think we have reached a point of no return in our movement. We have squarely to face reality and challenge the established order as it exists on all fronts.

